



Figure 1: Default desktop

the complex OS got too difficult to maintain in Assembler, the C language was created and UNIX was re-written in C. By about 1977, Berkeley Software Distribution (that's BSD) started as a set of add-on software to Sixth Edition UNIX. Ultimately, by the time BSD 4.4 came out, it had forked off from AT&T's UNIX and was on its own. However, 4.4 was the last BSD version, because BSD had run into licensing and patent issues. After the legal battle, 4.4 came out in 2 versions—4.4 Encumbered, with a lot of AT&T and some proprietary code, and 4.4Lite, with only the Berkeley code.

4.4 Lite had huge chunks of the kernel missing—critical chunks, which made the kernel unusable. Two major projects started off, and each took the 4.4Lite code and started developing on their own. We know of them as NetBSD and FreeBSD. The former specialises in security, while the latter boasts of stability. Around the same time, Andrew Tannenbaum developed MINIX, a 16-bit UNIX clone to teach students operating system design. MINIX had nothing to do with UNIX sources. And, watching Andrew, Linus Torvalds came up with a 32-bit clone, called Freax. Freax did not have anything to do with either UNIX or MINIX sources. And after Freax was complete, the manager of Linus's FTP site changed the name to Linux, because he didn't like Freax. Thus we had five UNIX and UNIX-like operating system kernels: UNIX itself, NetBSD, FreeBSD, MINIX and Linux.

Bang Bang Bang—PC-BSD is here

Mac users love their OS, and Mac OS X is built on part of the FreeBSD 5 kernel and that entire userland. So some guy called Kris Moore took apart FreeBSD 6.0 (at that time it was the latest) and built his own OS around it. Version 1.0 was released on April 26, 2006. The OS aimed to be the most Mac-ish, using a BSD kernel, a highly customised version of KDE 3, and a revolutionary... ahem, Mac-like package management system.

Cut to the present: I'm sitting down in front of Mozilla Firefox 3.0.8, running on PC-BSD 7.1 Galileo Edition, based on the FreeBSD 7.2 pre-release kernel,



Figure 2: My desktop after changing a few things

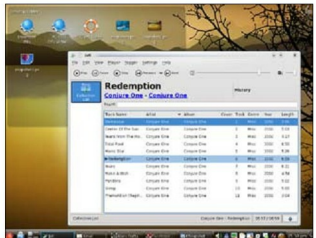


Figure 3: Enjoying my music on JuK

and running KDE 4.2.2. Savvy?

Yeah! PC-BSD is refreshing after the bores and chores of Linux. It comes on a plastic platter 15 centimetres in diameter, and to get it started, you install it. To do that, you must pluck out some sort of a tray from the front of your PC, put the platter silver side down on that tray, and close the tray. Then restart your computer, and follow the steps on that huge box that contains installation instructions.

After the actual installation is complete, the first boot needs some attention. After X starts up, a pop-up comes along, telling me to supply some information about my graphics card. I have an NVIDIA GeForce 7100/nForce 630i, and I don't like what I see. The string "vesa" is staring at me when I look at the field specifying the video driver. Not good. So I open up the drop down menu, and see three NVIDIA drivers—version 69, for legacy cards; version 173, the stable drivers; and version 180, the current drivers. I select version 180, and X re-starts. WhoHoo! I'm finally staring at KDE 4.2.2. At this moment on, there really is no difference between PC-BSD and Kubuntu. Well, save one: you don't have Apt here.

The software set is pretty standard, bundling in the